Chapter 4

A corpus-driven investigation of translation strategies for prenominal complex adjectives

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This chapter investigates a parallel corpus comprising original German texts and Italian translations from the field of tourism, with the objective of examining different translation strategies applied to Prenominal Complex Adjectives (PCAs). The study first categorizes German PCAs into seven groups. A regression analysis is then conducted to assess translation strategy frequencies. The results display a strong statistical correlation between categories and translation strategies, with a marked tendency to preserve the original syntactic structures. A qualitative analysis is carried out on the more unusual and transformational translation strategy of transposition in order to test its effectiveness for a complex syntactic structure characterized by two-directional syntactic reference. Results show that certain aspects of cognitive complexity in the original PCAs may encourage or trigger the application of transposition as a translation strategy for PCAs.

1 Introduction

This chapter investigates a parallel corpus of original German texts and their corresponding Italian translations to explore different translation strategies for German Prenominal Complex Adjectives (PCAs) into a language characterized by post-nominal attribution.

Section 2 introduces the phenomenon of prenominal complex adjectives as discussed in the literature and contrasts it with the definition adopted in this work, which is based on comparative reasoning tailored to the analytical goals



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of the study. Section 3 outlines the methodology, presenting parallel corpora as suitable sources for the quantitative and descriptive investigation of syntactic phenomena both within a single language and in contrastive terms. This follows the framework of corpus-based contrastive linguistics, as described in Laviosa (1998, 2003), Ebeling & Hasselgård (2018), and Johansson (1997, 2003, 2011), and includes a description of the corpus used. Section 4 presents the results of the extraction of PCA occurrences from the source corpus, leading to a linguistic characterology in the sense of Mathesius (1975). Section 5 provides a corpus-driven translational analysis aimed at identifying statistically significant translation strategies and evaluating the consistency of exceptional translation patterns, along with their potential generalization. This analysis follows the framework of Descriptive Translation Studies (Baker 1993; Toury 1991; Tognini Bonelli 2000, Tognini-Bonelli 2001; Laviosa 2002). Finally, some conclusions are drawn in sectrefsec:resi:6.

The complexity of the German structure between determiner and substantive requires syntactic referencing in both directions. It is assumed that the semantic content embedded in complex adjectival constructions is, in some cases, elevated to a higher semantic level within the sentence. This necessitates specific translation strategies when rendering such structures into Italian. Among these strategies, transposition is not frequently employed for PCAs, yet it remains a valid, and at times the most suitable, option.

2 The phenomenon of prenominal complex adjectives

A Prenominal Complex Adjective (PCA) can be described as a compound or phrase that appears before a noun and modifies it, similar to a regular attributive adjective. These constructions are considered ”complex” because they consist of more than one word, yet function syntactically as a single attributive adjective —that is, they are placed prenominally and follow the rules of adjective inflection (i.e., endings vary according to case, gender, and number). For a construction to qualify as a PCA, it must meet the following conditions: it must be prenominal (preceding the noun), complex (composed of more than one word), and adjectival (serving a noun-modifying function).

SOV languages, including German, tend to exhibit a wide range of constructions that fall under this definition, although the notion of complexity is not always applied consistently. In particular, morphological complexity in adjectival compounds (1), or the structural peculiarity of lining more than one adjective before the noun (2), is often not regarded as a PCA to the same extent as a participial structure like (3).

(1) die subnationale Ebene nimmt wichtige ausgabenrelevante
the subnational level takes important relevant_for_expenses
Aufgaben wahr
tasks PART.

(2) ist eine Anerkennung ihres außergewöhnlichen universellen Wertes
is a acknowledgment it$_{GEN}$ extraordinary universal value

(3) dass die auf der Grundlage der Marketingverträge erworbenen
that the on the basis of marketing_contracts acquired
Dienstleistungen
services

Research on the complexity of prenominal adjectives across German and other languages tends to be analyzed in terms of syntactic operations, often excluding the morphological complexity of compounds. Moreover, lists of prenominal adjectives that are not syntactically coordinated by *und* 'and' are generally not considered complex, although the contrastive perspective provided in sectref-sec:resi:3.3 and recalled in Section 4.4 suggests otherwise. An idea of that is provided by Kotowski & Härtl (2019) who claim that multiple adjective sequences are shaped not only by syntactic rules but also by pragmatic and cognitive factors governing information structure and linearization preferences.

German provides valuable insight into the structure of prenominal adjectives. Some of these adjectives show properties similar to full sentences, such as case assignment and scope, which suggests that they may have originally come from or represent more complex propositional structures (Fanselow 1986). Their placement within noun phrases is also shaped by interactions between agreement rules, inflectional endings, and word order, often going beyond the patterns seen in simpler attributive constructions (van Riemsdijk 1983).

Under a contrastive point of view, the work of Cinque (2010) provides a comparative account of prenominal and postnominal adjectives across Germanic and Romance language families, emphasizing structural differences rooted in syntactic hierarchies. The way adjective syntax has developed in these two language families shows both clear differences and shared patterns (Van de Van De Velde et al. 2014). Within Germanic languages, the variation in adjective endings, like the use of strong vs. weak forms, helps organize how adjectives appear before nouns, revealing a systematic pattern across these languages (Roehrs 2015).

German grammars aimed at both native speakers and learners of German as a foreign language (DaF) (Götze & Hess-Lüttich 2002; Engel 1988; Dreyer &

Schmitt 2001; Scollo 2020, among others) describe what we refer to as prenominal complex adjectives (PCAs), although they do so under various chapter headings and terminologies. A particularly detailed and systematic account of the structure between determiner and noun in German is provided by Eichinger (2006), who distinguishes three noun phrase positions—left, centre, and right—while designating the position to the left of the noun as the flexion point. Eichinger's framework accounts for several syntactic configurations, including present or past participles modified by materials, and adjectives modified by adverbs. However, it does not encompass the full range of PCA structures identified in our corpus, notably excluding compound adjectives and non-coordinated multiple adjectives.

Research on prenominal complex adjectives reveals a rich interplay between syntactic structure, morphosyntactic inflection, and typological variation across languages. The aspect concerning compounding between the determiner and the noun is typically addressed separately and not treated as a case of complexity within prenominal adjectival constructions. Also the situation of lining up more than one adjectives before noun is not always interpreted as complex.

To establish a consistent framework, we therefore examined the corpus of German texts using the approach of "linguistic characterology" (Mathesius 1975). This method aims to identify language-specific structural properties to enable a more precise understanding of their internal differentiation and typological relevance. The rationale for introducing a general label that encompasses all PCA types is grounded in a contrastive perspective. Specifically, we found no evidence in Italian of prenominal structures exhibiting a comparable degree of complexity between the determiner and the noun. Therefore, in addition to the requirements of prenominality, complexity, and adjectival modification outlined above, the linguistic characterology of German for the purpose of our study includes another distinctive feature that sets these structures apart: the absence of a structurally equivalent pattern in the Italian language.

3 Methodology

3.1 The corpus

The intuitive view about translation strategies for such a complex German language structure was derived largely from recursive, albeit independent, observations during translation from German into Italian in different text typologies. A more systematic test was deemed necessary for how PCAs are translated into a language that is generally unreceptive to this kind of structure. In order to

achieve detachment from any personal introspections, it was decided to address a corpus of texts completely separate from the translation work of the present authors.

The corpus was compiled on Sketch Engine (Kilgarriff et al. 2004) as a parallel corpus in the sense of Hartmann (1980: 37) and consists of original German texts and their translations into Italian. Following the definitions provided by Granger (2003: 19), such a corpus can also be defined as a translation corpus. The original corpus comprises 24 informative texts from the sphere of tourism with translations intended for an equivalent target. Tourism was chosen as a common but entirely arbitrary field to constrain the selection of texts within certain limits, but without restricting analysis to a specific text typology. Original texts with their translation were collected from the Internet mostly from the European Union website in order to maintain a certain translation standard and include both informative and promotional texts. The corpus includes legal acts (e.g. EU regulations), tourism brochures issued by the European Commission, communications promoting, amongst others, social tourism, and special reports on EU financed projects in the field of tourism. This miscellaneous field made it possible to compile a heterogeneous corpus as regards text typology, without confining research to trends in a specific kind of language, and so attempting to lay the foundations for more universal observations. The corpus includes a total of amount of 700,000 original words.

Combining the study corpus with comparable corpora (in the sense of Johansson & Hasselgard 1999) was avoided for two explicit reasons. Firstly, because providing evidence of syntactic differences between the two languages was not a primary goal but instead a presupposition. It was assumed that the Italian language does not accept this category of complex adjectival forms before nouns. The main aim of the preliminary analysis is a systematic categorization of this German syntactical phenomenon, which descriptive grammars do not treat as a unified whole. However, considered from a contrastive point of view, it can be treated as a single category: the inclusion of complex adjectival information between determiner and main noun. Secondly, there is no need to compare original and translated language, with instead the aim of identifying and investigating possible translation strategies into Italian. All that is required are parallel texts that convey exactly the same meanings by exploiting the syntactic possibilities of the target language. Moreover, the translated texts were also considered within the framework of Translation Studies, classing them as texts in their own right in order to "understand what translation is and how it works" (Baker 1993: 243).

3.2 The software

The *Sketch Engine* software was used to compile the corpus in order to be able to navigate the two languages separately. The corpus was intended for the two different purposes of clearly categorizing this syntactical phenomenon in the German language, and then for analysing the translation of the same phenomenon into Italian in relation to the defined classification.

Despite having an electronic corpus and a search engine to navigate it, a certain amount of manual investigation was still required to establish what was needed. There is a clear difference between using corpora to search for lexical items and using corpora to find syntactic phenomena. Syntactic features like the one under investigation here cannot be reduced to adequate algorithms because they embrace too many syntactical variables. While *Sketch Engine* was able to successfully identify all adjectives in the corpus and list them coherently according to frequency or alphabetical order, manual analysis was necessary to extract the smaller set of PCAs object of the study. Automatic searches retrieved a lot of irrelevant material but fortunately this was easy to eliminate because *Sketch Engine* provides a very clear overview of occurrences.

The analysis of Italian translations also required some time for the manual extraction of correspondences. *Sketch Engine* was not always able to spot the exact textual segment that included the translation of PCAs. The reason for such failures is presumably because the software in unable not spot a syntactically equivalent structure in the target language. Unlike lexical corpus analysis, you cannot look for a syntactic feature in a language that does not provide for it. Syntactic relationships do not covey specific semantic ideas, but rather semantic relationships within the original language, making automatic comparisons much more difficult. The use of *Sketch Engine* did however mean that for every occurrence it was possible to generate a list of sentences containing the item by simply by clicking on it. It still required some times to extract the complex adjectives from the lists, but less than would have been necessary working entirely manually. Each case was then schematized in an Excel table according to characteristic features, which will be explained in the next section.

4 Linguistic typology of PCAs in German

The way *Sketch Engine* works with its limits in matching syntactic features made it necessary to export data to another file format and reconstruct a subcategorization of the phenomenon of Prenominal Complex Adjectives (PCAs).

As defined in sectrefsec:resi:2 a PCA includes more than a single lexical adjective normally positioned between the determiner and the noun, but in all cases before the target noun. Among all the German PCAs identified, seven different types were observed:

- predicative structures with past participles (4);

(4) dass die auf der Grundlage der Marketingverträge erworbenen
that the on the basis of marketing_contracts acquired
Dienstleistungen
services

- predicative structures with present participles (5);

(5) die unter dem EU-Durchschnitt liegenden Beschäftigungsquoten
the under the EU_average lying employment_rates

- compound adjectives (6);

(6) die subnationale Ebene nimmt wichtige ausgabenrelevante
the subnational level takes important relevant_for_expenses
Aufgaben wahr
tasks PART

- multiple non-coordinated prenominal adjectives (7)

(7) ist eine Anerkennung ihres außergewöhnlichen universellen Wertes
is a acknowledgment its$_{GEN}$ extraordinary universal value

- adjectives modified by adverbs (8);

(8) Für neu eingestellte Piloten
For new employed pilots

- adjectives modified by more complex structures (9);

(9) die für künftiges Wachstum verfügbaren Qualifikationen
the for future growth available qualifications

- infinitive structures (10).

(10) in Form von vollständig zu überprüfenden und aufzubereitenden Daten
in form of completely to test and prepare data

Moreover, it is considered necessary to set some rules for data extrapolation in order to establish a coherent data set and avoid an excessive number of exceptions that would add further variables to the investigation of an already extended phenomenon. The rules are as follows:

- Sentences including two categories of PCAs are counted twice.
- Only qualifying adjectives with semantic meanings are considered for categorization of adjectival constructs. So when considering at the category "multiple non-coordinated adjectives", negations like *kein* and possessive adjectives are excluded from the count.
- Texts or headers in tables and graphics are excluded. Only syntactic structures embedded in complete clauses, sentences, and paragraphs are considered because contextualization plays a major role in translation strategies and it is important to consider at least what comes before and after any analyzed elements before making a translation decision.

The list is the result of corpus extraction, but the broadness of the corpus, and knowledge of German grammar, makes it plausible to assume that it represents a comprehensive characterology of the syntactic phenomenon in question. In the following subchapters categories are discussed individually.

4.1 Partizip I and Partizip II before the noun

A contrastive German-Italian analysis of so-called "enlarged" German constructions is provided by Kather (2011: 67–73) and Coletsos (2007: 65–86), in which a lot of examples of both Partizip I and Partizip II in attributive function are described together with their possible translations into Italian. The "costruzoni attributive allargate" are presented as a single attributional phenomenon and not as one possible expression of the syntactical complexity of attribution. A first look at the list of examples of PCAs constructed with past or present participles modified by syntactical elements demonstrates that this is a much more prolific structure than previously imagined, not only in more normative texts as expected but also in informative and popular texts including promotional materials for tourist destinations.

4.2 Past participles before nouns

In descriptive grammars of the German language, past participles before nouns are treated in the same section as normal adjectives, which traditionally assume a prenominal position in German. Observed contrastively, it is seen that in the Italian language PCAs are limited to specific situations related to subjectivity, and past participles never meet the semantic requirements to stand before nouns (because resistant to subjective interpretation). Past participles, even as adjectives on their own, do not occur as prenominal adjectives in standard use, although the influence of the English language seems to have changed that recently (see sectrefsec:resi:4).

When extracting occurrences of this category, simple prenominal past participles were excluded because of the lack of syntactic complexity. Prenominal simple past participles can be treated in translation like simple adjectives and do not need further investigation other than an awareness of a contrastive difference in the positioning of adjective forms.

Much more relevant is the analysis of prenominal past participles preceded by arguments like (4), (11), (12), and (13) which are sometimes considered reductions of relative clauses (Heidolph et al. 1984).

(11) Die Art der von der Kommission und anderen Nutzern der
The type of by the commission and other users of_the
europäischen Tourismus-Statistik benötigten Daten
European tourism-statistics needed data

(12) die entsprechenden Informationen wurden direkt bei 206 nach dem
The relevant information were directly from 206 by the
Zufallsprinzip ausgewählten Projektträgern eingeholt
random_principle selected project_sponsors taken

(13) 94% der durch die Projekte geschaffenen oder erhaltenen
94% of_the by the projects created or received
Arbeitsplätze waren weiterhin vorhanden
jobs were still available

The corpus provides a total of 310 cases of prenominal complex past participles.

4.3 Present participles before nouns

A similar situation is seen in syntactic situations like (5), (14), and (15) in which a present participle adjective assigns one or more arguments to the left.

(14) die mit ihm zusammenhängenden Branchen
the with it connected sectors

(15) wegen nach den letzten Entwicklungen unzureichender
due_to following the recent developments insufficient
Transparenz der Methodik
transparency of_the methodology

Present participles are sometimes difficult to identify because many of them have become lexicalized and acquired the status of adjectives. It was nevertheless decided to consider all adjectives derived from present participles, so as not to have to differentiate as regards the process of adjectivization, which is already rather controversial. Adjectives like *folgend* are counted as present participles and only considered in the analysis when preceded by other syntactical elements that increase the overall complexity.

The corpus provides a total of 205 cases of prenominal complex past participles.

4.4 Compound adjectives

German is a highly productive language as far as compounds are concerned. No syntactic categories are excluded from the compounding mechanism although some are more productive than others. As a category, adjectives are very productive, not only by combining an adjectival head with different syntactic categories, but also because the syntactic relationship between individual elements are not limited to specification. Non-endocentric compounds involve complex relationship as in (6) or (16) and so even if compound adjectives are single word adjectives they can be contrastively considered to be complex structures.

(16) die tourismusstatistischen Ausgangsdaten
the tourism_statistics starting_data

(17) um den haushaltspolitischen Rahmen Österreichs zu
in_order_to the fiscal_policy framework of_Austria to
verbessern
improve

(18) eine gesamtstaatliche Strategie zur digitalen Sicherheit
a national_level strategy for digital security

The extensive analysis of Pümpel-Mader et al. (1992) on different kinds of syntactical relationship between the individual elements of adjectival compounds, including those constructed with past and present participles, demonstrates how prolific and complex the German language is in this respect. Two specific types of compounds stand out in our translation analysis. The first category encompasses compound adjectives, such as (17), where the head lacks inherent semantic content and primarily assumes a functional role. Although individually the head possesses lexical meaning, it essentially functions as a suffix to derive the adjective from the noun that precedes it. In terms of translation strategy, the focus should be on encapsulating the lexical meaning within the adjective, primarily derived from the first element of the compound, like *quadro fiscale*. Moreover, there are adjectival compounds that carry the most important lexical information in the head of the compound, as in (18). These compounds usually require a more elaborate translation strategy to account for the entire meaning of the adjective.

The corpus contains 96 examples of compound adjectives.

4.5 Multiple non-coordinated prenominal adjectives

The Italian language does accept two or more prenominal adjectives, however this is not a common construction and only appears under rare circumstances determined by exceptional adjectival meanings. It was therefore decided to consider this as a syntactic difference. Prenominal adjectives are used when they provide a "natural" classification in combination with the noun: hence the oddness of **indaffarato vecchio uomo* compared to *un simpatico vecchio uomo*. It appears that prenominal adjectives have to denote some plausibly characteristic property of the noun they modify. In German by contrast, two or more adjectives are standard and admissible for any type of adjective, with postnominal adjectives completely excluded (7, 19, 20 and 21).

(19) dass die erlassenen delegierten Rechtsakte für die Mitgliedsstaaten
that the issued delegated legal_acts for the member_states

(20) angesichts des reichsten architektonischen Erbes der Welt
given the richest architectural heritage in_the world
und einer bahnbrechenden städtebaulichen Entwicklung
and a groundbreaking urban development

(21) so dass insgesamt 145 Projekte zu einer erhöhten touristischen Aktivität
so that a_total_of 145 projects to a increased tourist activity
beitragen
contribute

It is therefore necessary to exclude adjectives that are linked by coordination (22), because they do not satisfy the requirement of complexity.

(22) um wirtschaftlichen, sozialen und technologischen
in_order_to economic, social and technological
Entwicklungen Rechnung zu tragen
developments into_account to take

Pümpel-Mader et al. (1992) includes adjectives linked by hyphens in the analysis of adjectival compounds, stating that the hyphen indicates a status of semantic parity/equivalence with the noun, hence coordination. Few cases of this hyphen relation are found in the corpus, confirming the hypothesis of coordination. Since coordination does not indicate for complexity, such cases are excluded from the categorization of PCAs.

(23) grün-goldene Landschaft: eine Landschaft, die grün und golden ist
green-gold landscape a landscape which green and gold is

When it comes to non-coordinated adjectives like (19), (20), and (21) there are rules governing the sequencing of adjectives, with those expressing opinions coming before those expressing facts, with the latter also subject to additional ordering. However, there are also syntactic relationships between non-coordinated prenominal adjectives that need to be more closely investigated. A good way of explaining these relationships is a branching tree structure, especially from a perspective of contrast, since long sequences of prenominal or postnominal adjectives are not an option in Italian, and translation strategies like nominalization were considered even if marginally. In the case of (7′) for example, the adjective *außergewöhlich* does not refer directly to the noun but rather to the subsequent adjective *universell*, with the extraordinary nature referred to the universal character of the meaning, functioning almost like an adverb. The second adjective, which characterizes the noun, was in fact nominalized in an attempt to make this relation clear (see Section 4.5 for more on this translation strategy)

(7′) ihres außergewöhnlichen universellen Wertes
la straordinaria universalità del suo valore
the extraordinary universality of its value

In most cases (19, 20, and 21) the first adjective refers to the entire following sequence of adjective+noun and only rarely does the first adjective refer directly to the noun.

(20′) bahnbrechenden städtebaulichen Entwicklung
groundbreaking urban development

(21′) erhöhten touristischen Aktivität
increased tourist activity

The corpus contains 390 cases of multiple non-coordinated adjectives before nouns.

4.6 Adjectives modified by adverbs

In a similar way that English adverbs can modify adjectives, in German prenominal adjectives can be modified or intensified with adverbs. When adverbs are used to modify adjectives, they provide more information about the quality or degree of the adjective and are positioned before the adjectives (8, 24, 25, and 26).

(24) Im Gegensatz dazu könnten die stetig steigenden
On the contrary could the steadily increasing
Wohnimmobilienpreise…
residential_real_estate_prices…

(25) kostenlos zur Verfügung gestellte Unterkünfte
free_of_charge provided accomodation

(26) auch zu teilweise oder vollständig subventionierten Preisen
also at partially or fully subsidized prices

The adverbs *stetig*, *kostenlos*, *teilweise* and *vollständig* modify the following adjective. These adverbs help convey the degree or intensity of the quality described by the adjective. It is important to note that while the positioning of adverbs can vary in German sentences, they generally come before adjectives when they function as intensifiers of the same. As in the category described before, the syntactical relationship is not directly with the noun, but rather with the adjective which acquires a pivotal importance in the NP structure.

The corpus contains 208 cases of prenominal adjectives modified by adverbs.

4.7 Adjectives modified by more complex structures

Most other languages like English that accept premodification systematically exclude adjectives with complements from the prenominal modifier position (Sadler & Arnold 1994). German does allow for such constructions, sometimes even with long complex structures between determiner and noun (9, 27, 28).

(27) bei einer an dem besuchten Ort ansässigen Einheit
by a in the visited place living subject
alle dipendenze di un soggetto residente nel luogo visitato
by a subject living in_the place visited

(28) eine nicht mit dem Binnenmarkt vereinbarte staatliche Beihilfe
a not with the internal_market agreed_upon state aid
darstellt
represent

In the literature on these prenominal complex structures generated in situ, there are three main hypotheses: prenominal adjectives are heads, adjuncts, or specifiers (Roehrs 2023). On the other hand, since German Aps, unlike other languages, are able to take as many arguments as desired in the prenominal position, a clausal analysis of adjectives is also generally represented (since Kayne 1994). PCAs are considered the result of relative clauses undergoing movement and deletion (Cinque 2010). According to Resi (2011), the Head Raising Analysis appears more promising for German restrictive relative clauses, when regardless of position with respect to the head noun, they are considered the complement of D° within a DP and can move to the left into a higher position. Alternatively a Matching Analysis is preferred for appositive relative clauses which are adjuncts to the right to full DPs and are therefore islands for movement to the left. In the case of appositive relative clauses, embedment between the determiner and the noun is in fact excluded.

The corpus contains 51 cases of prenominal adjectives modified by adverbs.

4.8 Infinitive structures

German can provide extensive information about a noun simply by positioning an entire phrase as a modifier before a noun. In the above example there is no finite (conjugated) verb and the participles have endings, indicating that they are functioning as adjectives. The phrase therefore modifies a noun and is not an independent sentence. The present corpus provided few examples of infinitive

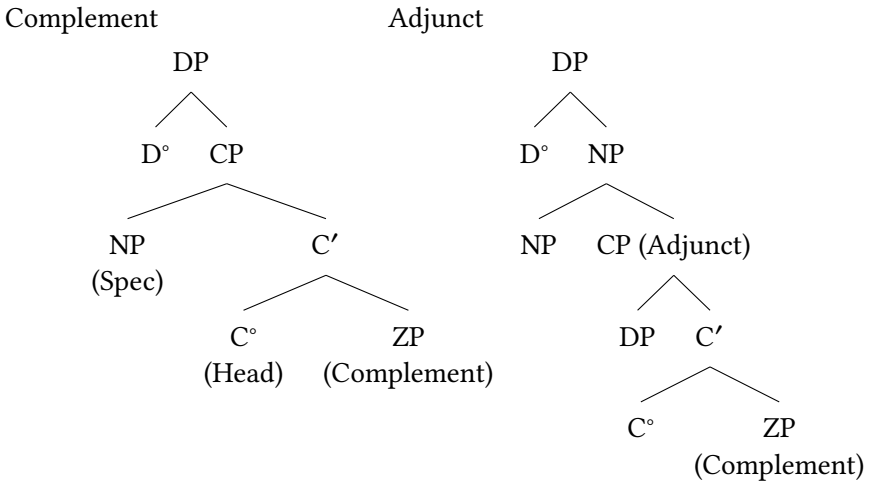


Figure 1: Derivation of German restrictive relative clauses and appositive relative clauses (Resi 2011)

structures embedded as modifiers of nouns, in which adjectivization of the verb in its infinitive form is required, as in (10), and (29).

(29) die von den Mitgliedstaaten gemäß Artikel 9 zu übermittelnden
the by the Member_States according_to Article 9 to be_transmitted
Daten
data

This formulation occurs 72 times in the corpus and it is contrastively very complex because it often combines an infinite clause with multiple modifying phrases, all working together to provide detailed information about the noun.

Figure 2 provides a graphical overview of the distribution of PCAs.

5 PCAs in Italian

5.1 Restrictions on PCAs in Italian

According to Cerruti (2015), prenominal positioning of complex adjectival phrases in a more restricted sense – hence ruling out adjectival compounds and infinite structures – is not entirely excluded in Italian, but it is more common in some contexts than in others. It occurs more frequently in the presence of internal factors such as prepositional phrases, relative clauses, or the coexistence

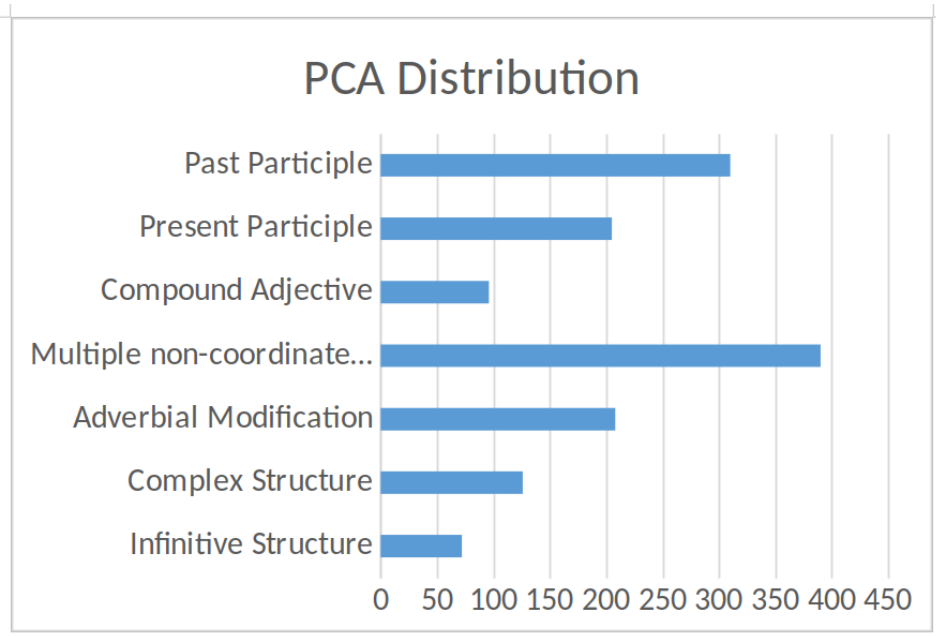


Figure 2: : Graphic distribution of PCAs

of multiple modifiers of different types, to achieve a more balanced distribution of adjectival information within the nominal phrase.

(30) menomato e perciò costretto a una per lui insopportabile
impaired and therefore forced into an for him unbearable
inattività
inactivity

(31) il mero e odierno schieramento della sinistra ufficiale
the mere and current alignment of_the left official

(Cerruti 2015)

The structures in (30) and (31) have increased significantly in recent years in journalistic language under the influence of massive exposure to English. However, despite the possibility of PCAs in Italian identified by Cerruti in a corpus of press articles and revealing clearly increasing trend, Italian is still strongly characterized by postnominal attribution (Berruto 1998; Cardinaletti & Garzone 2005). In the translation corpus of the present study, no examples of PCAs were found in Italian. This absence can be attributed to two main causes. First and

foremost, the corpus does not include press articles, effectively excluding the journalistic style from consideration. Secondly, the intricacy of these structures in the original language did not significantly influence the translation decision-making process.

Considering the exceptionality of PCAs in Italian, it can effectively be sustained that there is no direct equivalent for PCAs in Italian. References to "preserving the syntactical structure in translation" should be understood as the most similar structure, regardless of its position relative to the head noun. So an embedded structure could be preserved by translating it with a relative clause or reduced relative clause after the noun, or a list of prenominal adjectives could become a list of postnominal adjective, and so on.

5.2 Analysis of translation strategies for PCAs in Italian

Considering the abovementioned lack of direct equivalence for PCAs in Italian, translations of German texts were examined in an effort to identify different translation strategies dealing with the various kinds of PCAs. In this phase the use of Sketch Engine was fundamental but not enough in itself. It was easy to identify paragraphs in which these structures were translated, but the ordering of elements in Italian was completely different, making further manual analysis necessary.

All the adopted strategies resulted in postnominal attribution of the semantic meanings found in the original German PCAs, which was relatively predictable. The translation strategies were categorized according to frequency. Overall, a statistically significant equivalence for these structures in the Italian texts was the positioning of the attribution with its modifiers and arguments after the head noun in 45% of cases (32), postnominal full relative clauses in about 30% of cases (33), and post-nominal adjective lists in around 20% of cases.

(32) a. Die Art der von der Kommission und den Nutzern
The type of the from_the commission and the users
benötigten Daten
required data

b. Il tipo di dati richiesti dalla commissione e dagli
The type of data required from_the commissione and from_the
utenti
users

(33) a. Die entscheidende dem Tourismus bei der Förderung von
The crucial to_the tourism in the promoting the
Wachstum und Beschäftigung zukommende Rolle
growth and employment given role

b. Il ruolo fondamentale che il turismo acquisisce nella
The role crucial that the tourism acquires in
promozione di crescita e occupazione.
the promotion of growth and employment

(34) a. eine Bandbreite möglicher marktkonformer jährlicher Prämien
a range of_possible market-compliant annual premiums

b. Una paletta di premi annuali plausibili conformi al
A range of premiums annual possible compliant with_the
mercato
market

The most frequent strategy in the study corpus is a postnominal adjectival construction, encompassing all adjectives modified to the right by syntactic elements. In this strategy it is important to note that the boundaries of the constructions to the right of the nouns are not always clearly defined in Italian. An analysis of translations from Italian to German should be able to reveal examples of this ambiguity. Indeed, the primary challenge associated with this strategy lies in the ambiguity of reference for adjectival modification. In fact, a sentence like (35) can be transferred into German either with the arguable and ambiguous (35a) or with the fully acceptable (35b), which comprises all arguments in the PCA.

(35) I contratti stipulati nel quadro del programma di
The contracts signed in the framework of the
promozione
program of promotion

a. ?Die abgeschlossenen Verträge im Rahmen des
The signed contracts in_the framework of_the
Förderungsprogramms
promotion_program

b. ?Die im Rahmen des Förderungsprogramms
The in_the framework of_the promotion_program
abgeschlossenen Verträge
signed contracts

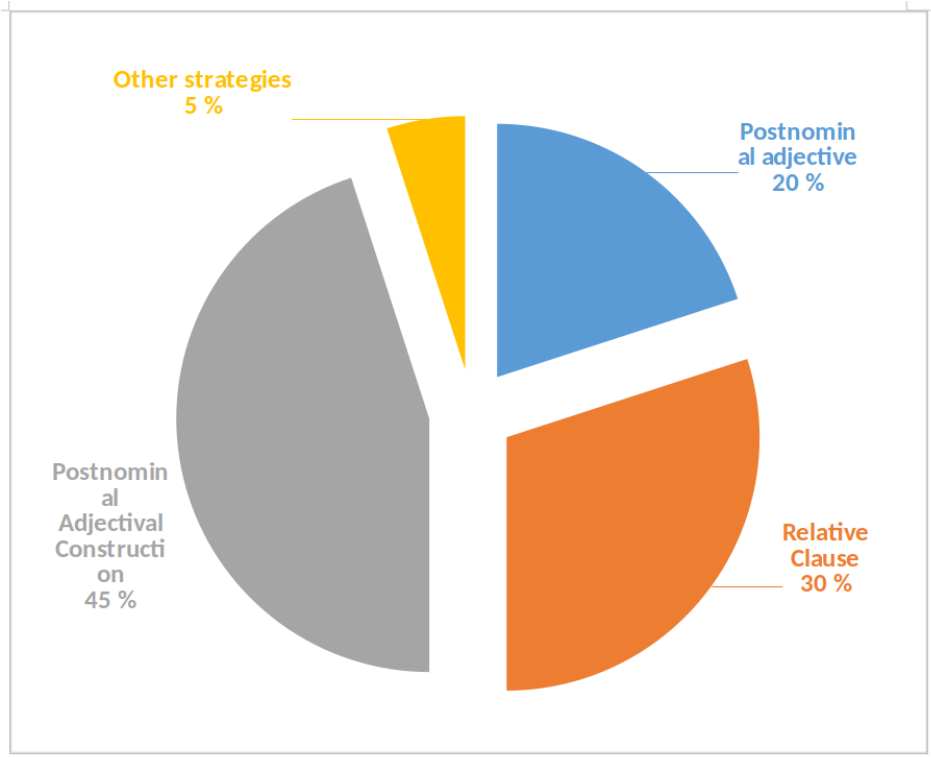


Figure 3: Percentage of different translation strategies

The fact that the grammaticality of (35a) is not completely excluded is not surprising since the original corpus contains cases of discontinuity between the elements making up the adjectival phrase (36a) resulting in decontextualized ambiguous interpretation of the temporal argument *für 2012 und 2013*. Our proposal in (36b) would have solved the ambiguous reference of the argument, but (36a) was preferred in the original text.

(36) a. ?Das Burgenland und Vorarlberg wurden aufgrund fehlender
The Burgenland and Voralberg were due_to missing
vorliegender Daten für 2012 und 2013 ausgeschlossen
actual data for 2012 and 2013 excluded

b. ?Das Burgenland und Vorarlberg wurden aufgrund für 2012 und 2013
The Burgenland and Voralberg were due_to for 2012 and 2013
fehlender vorliegender Daten ausgeschlossen
missing actual data excluded

The second translation strategy is full postnominal relative clauses, in most cases (but not exclusively) used to translate embedded constructions of the sixth category like (37), which recalls example (9).

(37) a. könnten die für künftiges Wachstum verfügbaren Qualifikationen
could the for future growth available qualifications
begrenzen
limit

b. potrebbe finire per limitare le qualifiche che andrebbero a
could end_up for limiting the qualifications that would_go to
supportare una crescita futura
support a growth future

Full postnominal relative clauses are also the second most common strategy for translating both past (30%) and present participles (28%) as in (38) and (39).

(38) a. da die von Ryanair an den Flughafen Frankfurt-Hahn gezahlten
since the from Ryanair to the airport Frankfurt-Hahn paid
Flughafenentgelte
airport_taxes

b. le tasse aeroportuali che Ryanair pagò all' aeroporto di
the taxes airport which Ryanair paid to_the airport of
Frankfurt-Hahn
Frankfurt-Hahn

(39) a. womit der seit 2012 bestehende Trend anhält
with_whom the since 2012 persisting tendency continues

b. che preserverebbe la tendenza che perdura dal
which would_persist the tendency, that has_been_persisting since
2012
2012

Surprisingly, the relative clauses used in translation do not always appear to be restrictive, even though appositive relative clauses are excluded from the embedded position between determiner and head noun in German. Using a postnominal full relative clause as in (40) does not rule out the appositive meaning generating ambiguity, which was unintended in the original text. Again, it is the position of the sentence within the text that disambiguates the meaning.

(40) a. Mehrere vor kurzem umgesetzte Maßnahmen zielen darauf ab
Several till recently implemented measures aim at

b. Molte misure che sono state implementate di recente hanno
Several measures which were implemented of recently have
come obiettivo
as aim

The translation strategy of postnominal full relative clauses is not however exclusive to embedded participle constructions, but was also applied for other categories of complex adjectives. In some cases of compound adjectives (41) or lists of non-coordinate adjectives (42), the appositive meaning of the relative clause is required.

(41) a. dass stärker auf wachstumsfreundlichere Einnahmequellen
that stronger on growth_friendlier revenue_sources
zurückgegriffen wird
recurred is

b. che si possa fare sempre più affidamento su fonti di
that self can make always more trust on sources of
guadagno, le quali favorirebbero la crescita
revenue which would favor the growth

(42) a. Dank Österreichs allgemein gutem wirtschaftlichen
Thanks_to Austria's general good economic
Abschneiden ergibt sich die Gelegenheit
performance, it arises self the opportunity

b. Grazie allo sviluppo economico dell' Austria, che in
Thanks to_the development economic of Austria, which in
generale risulta positivo, si avrebbe la possibilità
general is positive, one would_have the possibility

The third most frequent translation strategy involves positioning adjectives postnominally, when adjectives are simply listed without any subsequent complement or adjunct (43). Completely postnominal attribution (43a) was often preferred rather than balancing adjectivization between the prenominal and postnominal positions as in Cerruti's analysis (2015) and proposed in (43c).

(43) a. hinter diesen Entwicklungen verbergen sich große regionale
behind these developments hide self big regional
Unterschiede
differences

b. dietro a questi andamenti si celano divergenze regionali grandi
behind these developments self hide differences regional big

c. ?dietro a questi andamenti si celano grandi divergenze
behind these developments self hide big differences
regionali.
regional

Each PCA example was matched to one of the translation strategies utilized within the translation corpus. This aimed to pinpoint the most commonly employed strategies within each category and present them quantitatively in a graphic format.

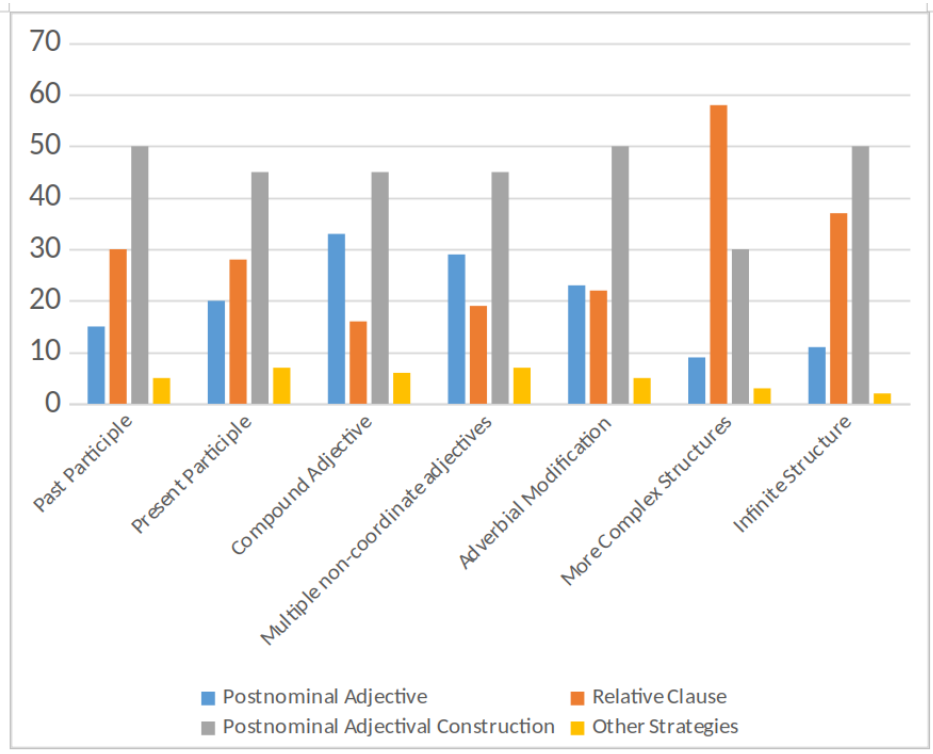


Figure 4: Distribution of translation strategies according to PCAs

A regression analysis (Gries & Wulff 2012) was conducted on the frequency of translation strategies for each category, considering approaches ranging from closest possible preservation of syntactic structure, to complete reformulation.

The results reveal a strong overall statistical significance of association between categories and translation strategies (P-value: 0.00001859) with an odds ratio far below the threshold of 1. A general tendency is also observed for preserving the original syntactic structure, resulting in positioning of attributions after the head noun in the form of relative clauses, post-nominal adjective lists, or other post-nominal constructions (e.g. adverbs), mainly adopting the most similar possible prenominal structure to the source text category.

Postnominal adjectival constructions emerged as the most frequently used approach across six out of seven categories of PCAs (from 30 to 50%). This indicates that the translators consistently employed the technique of constructing more complex noun phrases by positioning adjectives, potentially modified by other elements, after the noun (44).

(44) a. die unter dem EU-Durchschnitt liegenden Beschäftigungsquoten
the under the EU-average lying employment_rates

b. I tassi di occupazione al di sotto della media EU…
the rates of employment at of under the average EU…

This strategy, which also includes what could be defined as reduced relative clauses is explained later with (50) and (51), is the preferred choice for conveying the intended meaning in all contexts apart from adjectives modified by complex structures.

With compound adjectives, the translators consistently chose to position the adjectives or lists of adjectives after the noun, often simplifying the compound's nuances of meaning (33%). This straightforward approach was evidently effective for conveying the intended meaning of compound adjectives by taking into consideration the overall context (45). When the context is less clear and more precision is required in the translation of the compound, the same structure is translated without preserving the original grammatical categories (45c).

(45) a. unter normalen marktwirtschaftlichen Bedingungen
under normal market_economical conditions

b. in condizioni economiche normali
under conditions economical normal

c. in condizioni di normalità economica in un mercato..
under conditions of normality economical in a market

When dealing with multiple non-coordinated adjectives, the translators most often opted for simplicity by placing the adjectives after the noun (29%) as in (46), or by using relative clauses as in (47), a less common approach (19%)

(46) a. nicht zuletzt auch die unzureichenden digitalen Kompetenzen
not least also the insufficient digital competences

b. non per ultimo anche le competenze digitali insufficienti
not for least also the competences digital insufficient

(47) a. Die subnationale Ebene nimmt wichtige ausgabenrelevante
The subnational level takes important relevant_for_expenses
Aufgaben wahr
tasks PART

b. A livello subnazionale vengono acquisiti incarichi che richiedono
At level subnational are acquired tasks that require
grosse spese
big expenses

In cases of adverbial modification, the translators employed both relative clauses (22%) and postnominal adjectives (23%) with almost equal frequency after the primary choice of postnominal adjectival constructions. Interestingly, when translating complex structures preceding adjectives, relative clauses accounted for a larger portion of equivalence in meaning (58%), possibly due to the explicitness of their structures, this being a common strategy to effectively manage complexity. This preference for explicitation using relative clauses may derive from the specific cognitive complexity of the translation task. In the case of (48), it is surprising to see that the relative clause was not reduced to a postnominal adjectival structure by eliding the relative pronoun together with the functional verb like in (48b) compared to (48c).

(48) a. dass die auf der Grundlage der Marketingverträge erworbenen
that the on the basis of marketing_contracts acquired
Dienstleistungen
services

b. I servizi che vengono acquistati con contratti di marketing
The services that are acquired with contracts of marketing

c. I servizi acquistati con contratti di marketing
The services acquired with contracts of marketing

This is an indication of the general tendency to preserve the original structure of the sentence when possible (Cardinaletti & Garzone 2005) even after shifting to a position syntactically coherent with the grammar of the target language. The reduction of relative clauses is however not always excluded, as already seen. In

the following example the relative pronoun is also in nominative form but the adjectivized verb in infinitive form takes a direct object, probably reducing the complexity of the relationship within the adjectival construction (49).

(49) a. die auf die steigenden Treibhausgase zurückzuführenden
the to the increasing greenhouse_gases to_attribute
Umweltrisiken
environmental_risks

b. I rischi ambientali riconducibili ai crescenti gas
The risks environmental attributable to_the increasing gases
serra
greenhouse

Both the complexity of the relationship between the NP and the relative pronoun, and between the adjective and its preceding modifiers, tends generally to be decisive for the use or deletion of the relative pronoun and consequent reduction of relative clause in Italian. The few exceptions include (50) and (51).

(50) a. Auf ihren Märkten gut positionierte Reiseveranstalter
In their markets well positioned travel_companies

b. Tour Operator ben posizionati sui loro mercati
Travel companies well positioned in their markets

(51) a. Die 2013, 2015 und 2016 zwischen der FFHG und Ryanair
The 2013, 2015 and 2016 between the FFHG and Ryanair
geschlossenen Verträge
signed contracts

b. I contratti stipulati tra FFHG e Ryanair nel 2013, 2015
The contracts stipulated between FFHG and Ryanair in 2013, 2015
e 2016
and 2016

In summary, the reason for choosing one or another strategy probably lies in the semantics of each individual sentence, but with a clear preference for retaining the grammatical category of the original text, while shifting elements according to the rules of the target language. When preservation becomes marked, a certain degree of reformulation is implemented, accounting for about 5% of the translation strategies. Considering (52b), proposed here for the sake of comparison, it becomes clear that postposition of a list of adjectives would not be

a particularly elegant solution. Since *öffentliche Finanzen* is considered to be a single technical term with a standard translation, reformulation can only affect the adjective *solider*. *Solider* is in fact the only part of the NP that can be modulated for a more elegant translation approach. Nominalization of the adjective as in (52c) helps to resolve the oddness of the list of adjectives. In this specific case it offers a matching syntactic structure with "*stabilità*", which is also a noun. The translation in (52c) from the corpus appears more straightforward, although deviating from the grammatical categories of the original words.

(52) a. Gewährleistung makrofinanzieller Stabilität und solider
Guarantee macrofinancial$_{GEN}$ stability and solid$_{GEN}$
öffentlicher Finanzen
public$_{GEN}$ finances

b. ?Garanzia di stabilità macrofinanziaria e finanze pubbliche più
Guarantee of stability macrofinancial and finance public more
solide
solid

c. Garanzia di stabilità macrofinanziaria e solidità nelle finanze
Guarantee of stability macrofinancial and solidity in finances
pubbliche
public

Exceptional translation strategies hinted at in examples (45c) and (52c) will be further discussed in the next section.

5.3 Exceptional translation strategies: 5%

The present analysis of translation strategies reveals a particular subset comprising approximately 5% of total cases. Within this subset instances are identified in which adjectival structures undergo significant transformations during translation without any effort to preserve the original patterns. A qualitative analysis of this exceptional 5% brings some noteworthy scenarios to light.

Firstly, there are cases of total reformulation, with the original adjectival structures being entirely reconstrued in the target language, leaving no discernible trace of the original wording. For example the source text in example (53) is transformed without using adjectives, preserving the meaning by verbalizing the embedded information. The adjectival structure is completely reformulated, resulting in a distinct expression.

(53) a. auf eine durch die Mitgliedstaaten fristgerechte Umsetzung
toward a by the Member_States timely implementation
der Agenda für einen nachhaltigen und wettbewerbsfähigen
of_the agenda for a sustainable and competitive
Tourismus
tourism

b. affinché l' agenda per un turismo sostenibile e competitivo
so_that the agenda for a tourism sustainable and competitive
possa essere tempestivamente attuata dagli Stati membri
can be promptly implemented by_the Member States

Another case reveals a different approach, with adjectives being entirely omitted in the target language, although they can still be inferred from the surrounding context. For instance, the phrase in (54) is translated into Italian by eliminating the present participle *handelnder* completely and relying on the context to convey the intended meaning.

(54) a. ob ein unter normalen marktwirtschaftlichen Bedingungen
whether a under normal market_economic conditions
handelnder privater Anleger von vergleichbarer Größe
operating private investor of comparable size

b. se un investitore dello stesso calibro in
whether a private_investor of comparable size under
condizioni normali…
conditions normal

What raised most interest in the study are instances of transposition, when the adjectival structures are not omitted or completely reformulated but instead shifted in placement and form. These cases added an intriguing layer of complexity to the translation process, as they required a nuanced understanding of both source and target languages to ensure accuracy while accommodating the structural differences.

Traditionally, transposition involves moving from one grammatical category to another without altering the meaning of the text. As a translation technique it introduces a change in grammatical structure (Alcaraz Varó & Hughes 2002; Kather 2011). In the following examples from the corpus in this section, the translators change the grammatical category of the adjective, restructuring the dependencies between various syntactical elements. A German adjective usually becomes a noun phrase and a German noun phrase becomes its prepositional

phrase. Other information is added later in the form of additional syntactical structures. Cases of transpositions are found both as PCAs with past participles (55) and present participles (56), when adjectives like *festgelegt* or *zunehmend* are nominalized while nouns like *Kategorien* or *Zahl* become prepositional phrases of those nominalizations.

(55) a. die im Anhang II festgelegten Kategorien
the in attachment II defined categories

b. la definizione delle categorie di cui all' allegato II
the definition of_the categories of which in attachment II

(56) a. Eine stetig zunehmende Zahl
A constant increasing number

b. Un aumento costante del numero
an increase constant of the number

The complexity of the structure between determiner and noun requires a syntactical reference in both directions, and so it can be assumed that the semantic information within the complex structure in some cases is raised to a higher semantic level within the sentence, which must be taken into account with a specific strategy when translating into Italian.

Other cases of transposition are found within the set of prenominal adjectival compounds (57). Here the pattern is less well defined, as in (55) and (56), with the inflected component of the compound head becoming a noun, and other information attached afterwards.

(57) a. Tourismusstatistische Ausgangsdaten
tourism_statistic base_data

b. Le statistiche di base sul turismo
The statistics of base on tourism

Other transpositions are found in the category of multiple non-coordinated adjectives. As already seen with example (7), the syntactical relationship between the adjectives is guaranteed if we consider "*valore universale*" a single unit referred to by *straordinario*. The syntactical link is preserved without ambiguity again by choosing non-preservation of the grammatical category of the original text, hence nominalization. The same occurred in example (52) where nominalization of *solider* was favoured by the symmetry with the preceding NP *macrofinanzieller Stabilität.*

This way of treating PCAs is very interesting and may be based on an underlying logical syntactical mechanism. It was decided to investigate the possibility of applying the transposition strategy to other cases besides the few already identified in the corpus. This involved identifying the most important semantic information in the adjectival structure and nominalizing it in order to balance the structural shift. The transposition strategy was therefore tested on numerous examples that were translated using the more statistically significant strategies, a sample of which is provided here as (58) to (61), where examples (b) display more frequent translation startegies compared to examples (c) which display transposition.

(58) a. dass die auf der Grundlage der Marketingverträge erworbenen
that the on the basis of marketing_contracts acquired
Dienstleistungen
services

b. che i servizi che vengono acquistati con contratti di marketing
that the services that are acquired with contracts of marketing

c. che l' acquisizione di servizi tramite contratti di marketing.
that the acquisition of services through contracts of marketing

(59) a. zur Anpassung dieser Bedingungen an geänderte internationale
for adjusting $\text{these}_{\text{GEN}}$ conditions to revised international
Definitionen
definitions

b. per adattare queste condizioni alle definizioni internazionali
to adjust these conditions to_the definitions international
modificate
changed

c. per adattare queste condizioni alle modifiche delle definizioni
to adjust these conditions to_the changes of_the definitions
internazionali
international

(60) a. die stetig steigenden Wohnimmobilienpreise
the continually increasing real_estate_prices

b. I prezzi del mercato immobiliare costantemente in crescita
The prices of market real_estate continually in increase

c. la costante crescita dei prezzi del mercato immobiliare
the constant growth of prices of the market real estate

(61) a. qualitativhochwertige Arbeitsplätze gewährleisten
high_qualitative work_places guarantee

b. garantire posti di lavoro di qualità / garantire la qualità dei posti di lavoro
guarantee place of work of quality / guarantee the quality of_the place of work

The possibility of applying a transposition strategy derives from the intricate nature of the structural relationship between determiners and nouns in complex adjectival phrases. This intricacy requires simultaneous syntactical reference in both directions: from the adjective to the determiner, and from the noun to the adjective. The idea that sequences of adjectives can also be rendered with transposition supports the argument of Kotowski & Härtl (2019) that multiple adjective sequences are shaped by syntactic rules. This justify our categorisation of such structures as complex. The semantic information encapsulated within the complex adjectival structure sometimes can assums heightened significance within the overall sentence context, which must be considered when rendering such constructs into Italian.

It is also supposed that the complexity of the adjectival structure may influence the adoption of such translation strategies. It appears that the more complex the structure, the more frequently transposition can be considered an option. A set of sentences was defined, drawn from various categories of PCAs, and further scrutinized to assess the presence of distinct factors contributing to cognitive complexity (Rohdenburg 1996; Gries & Wulff 2011). These factors encompassed several elements, including:

- The occurrence of genitive case prepositions within the intricate adjectival structure.
- The presence of lengthy adjectival structures that create greater separation between the determiner and the noun phrase. This extension could result from the inclusion of more than two non-coordinated adjectives or the adverbial modification of adjectives (LenghtDB>3).
- The identification of relationships other than mere specification between the elements within an adjectival compound.

- Adjectives taking arguments and not merely complements within the complex structure. Arguments consist primarily of temporal (62) and local phrases (63) with a smaller portion of agent phrases (64).

(62) das 1998 gestartete Programm
the 1998 started program

(63) das in Österreich geltende Abkommen
the in Austria valid agreement

(64) den vom Verein vergebenen Preis
the from_the association given prize

The distribution of different factors within the selected subset of sentences is shown in the following graph:

Testing transposition on this subset of sentences suggests that genitive case prepositions within PCAs have a significant effect, not only enabling transposition but even triggering it. The translation provided in the corpus does not apply transposition (65) and is questionable (65b) while the proposed nominalization of the adjective *fehlend* following the preposition *wegen* is without doubt acceptable (65c).

(65) a. wegen fehlender gemeinsamer statistischer Merkmale und Qualitätsanforderungen
due_to missing common statistical features and quality_requirements

b. ?a causa di caratteristiche statistiche e requisiti di qualità comuni mancanti
due to features statistic and requirement of quality common missing

c. a causa della mancanza di caratteristiche e requisiti di qualità comuni
due_to the lack of features and requirement of quality common

The presence of adverbial modification with a long distance between the determiner and the noun phrase induces adjuvating effects (66b vs 66c). A combination of the two factors definitely requires transposition (67).

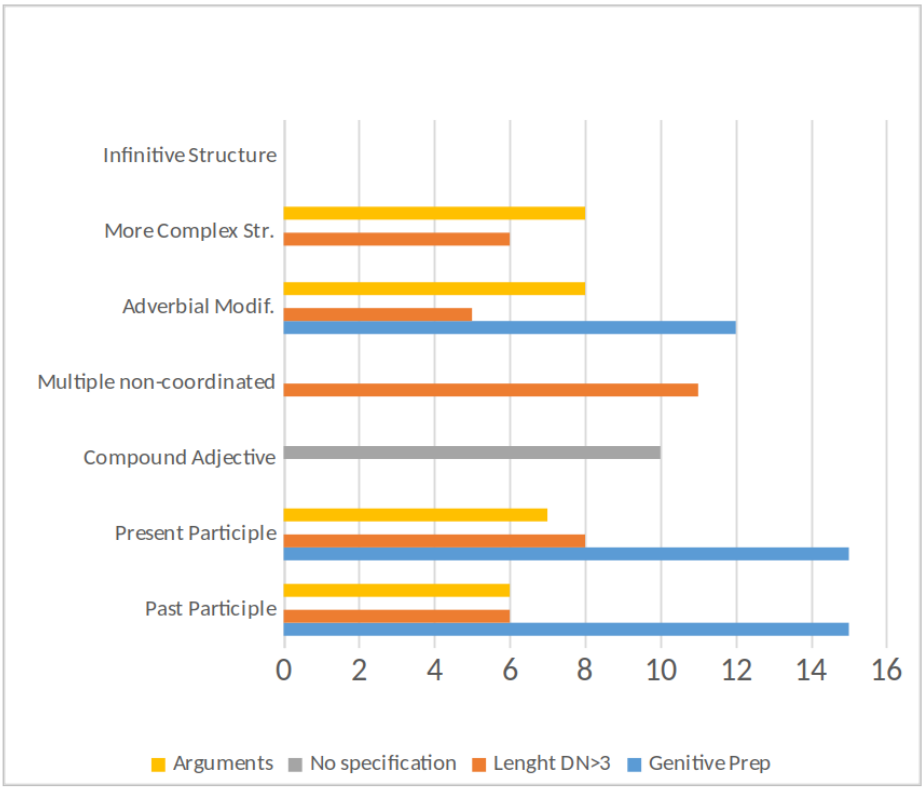


Figure 5: Complexity factors in different categories of PCAs

(66) a. so dass insgesamt 145 Projekte zu einer stark erhöhten
so that total 145 projects to a strong increased
touristischen Aktivität beitragen
touristic activity contribute

b. ?cosicché 145 progetti hanno contribuito ad un' attività turistica
so_that 145 projects have contributed to a touristic activity
fortemente in crescita
strongly in increase

c. cosicché 145 progetti hanno contribuito ad un forte aumento
so_that 145 projects have contributed o a strong growth
dell' attività turistica
of_the activity tourist

(67) a. trotz eines leicht rückläufigen Beitrags der Investitionen
despite a slight decreasing contribute of investments

b. *nonostante un contributo leggermente in calo degli
despite a contribute light in decrease of_the
investimenti
investments

c. nonostante un leggero calo dei contributi per gli
despite a light decrease of_the contributions for the
investimenti
investments

This strategy simplifies the sentence structure and makes it more natural in the target language, while preserving the original meaning. However, there is no straightforward correlation between the possibility of transposition and the other two complexity factors tested. Compound adjectives can thus be transposed with a nominalization strategy, but this possibility has more to do both with the complexity of relationships between individual elements and the semantics of the elements involved outside the compound itself. The same compound like *geschlechtspezifisch* comprises a specifying relationship which might require transposition in one sentence (68) but rule it out if combined with a different NP (69).

(68) a. die geschlechtsspezifische Segmentierung auf dem Arbeitsmarkt
the gender-specific segmentation on the job_market

b. la specificità di genere nella segmentazione del mercato
the specificity of gender in_the segmentation of_the market

(69) a. geschlechtsspezifischen Lohngefälles für Österreich
gender-specific wage_gap for Austria

b. ?specificità di genere nel divario degli stipendi in Austria
specificity of gender in_the gap of_the wages in Austria

The potential of transposition as a translation strategy was also explored by examining sentences without complicating factors, with the aim of determining whether transposition could be a viable alternative in these scenarios. Transposition is observed to be generally suitable as a translation approach in a wide range of cases, although it is worth noting that, particularly in cases of low complexity, preserving the original structure is just as good.

6 Conclusion

The essence of this study is based on an undeniable distinction between German and Italian, with the former predominantly employing prenominal attribution, and the latter strongly inclined toward postnominal attribution. The contrast emerges most prominently in the way that German allows substantial syntactic complexity between determiners and associated nouns. Italian has recently been adopting increasingly complex prenominal adjectival structures, especially lists of adjectives, under the influence of English. Nevertheless, PCAs are still confined to exceptional cases. Starting from this disparity, some pivotal questions for translators were investigated. How should they adapt to this linguistic divergence? What are the most successful translation strategies for navigating the intricacies of adjectival constructions?

This analysis ventures into some uncharted territory, particularly the comprehensive exploration of adjectival complexity, extending beyond participial adjectival phrases or reduced relative clauses. The applied conception of complexity was shaped by a cross-linguistic perspective, encompassing scenarios in which an equivalent level of complexity cannot be seamlessly transposed into the Italian language. Previous studies have focused primarily on dissecting specific aspects of adjectival phrase structure from both the monolingual and contrastive perspectives. The authors propose that the present study can extend the current understanding of German prenominal adjectivization and its Italian equivalent from a translational perspective.

The assembled corpus proved invaluable for identifying the phenomenon under study. Categorization was not an initial goal, but as study of the corpus proceeded, it became clear that a systematic classification was essential to thoroughly examine the different translation strategies. The classification also facilitated quantitative analyses, of both original texts and associated translation strategies. The quantitative analyses were aided by statistical calculations, revealing a significant correlation between German forms and translation strategies. It was also possible to corroborate the hypothesis that preserving the original structure is sometimes favoured over reformulation, even when the latter may seem more fluid.

After quantitative analysis, a qualitative exploration of exceptional translation strategies was conducted. Transposition emerged as particularly noteworthy due to its unexpected versatility. Transposition was assessed first within corpus examples, and then in controlled contexts, subsequently extending the examination to cases in which it was not used even though it could have been. Guided by the intuition that greater complexity in prenominal adjectives might lead to less

conservative translation strategies, several factors were postulated as contributing to the cognitive complexity of the structure. Among these, the presence of prepositions with indirect cases was seen to encourage nominalization of adjectives in translation, especially when a modifying adverb was enchained within the adjectival construction and the distance between the determiner and noun was substantial.

The intricate nature of German prenominal adjectival structures between determiners and nouns would suggest that a bidirectional syntactical reference is necessary. Consequently, the semantic information within these complex structures is sometimes raised to a higher semantic level within the sentence. In standard constructions the pivotal meaning is typically carried by the adjective. However, in adjectival compounds and prenominal adjective lists, discerning the highest level information requires a thorough comprehension of the semantics within the overall syntactic context. When this kind of complexity with bidirectionality is established, then transposition is an option. This phenomenon must be duly considered, prompting the development and application of targeted translation strategies when rendering these structures into Italian. On the basis of qualitative analysis of examples from the corpus and elsewhere, there is reason to believe that transposition represents a viable strategy for addressing this shift in attribution of meaning.

However, it is important to adopt a nuanced approach to translation strategies without being overly prescriptive. It is not possible to establish rigid rules for transposition as a translation strategy for PCAs. This depends also from the fact that syntactic complexity in prenominal environments is not only structural but also interfaces with semantic and discourse-related constraints.

Nevertheless, it is very helpful to be aware of the existence of transposition as a potential TS, particularly in some specific syntactical contexts, allowing translators to exploit its potential when appropriate. Transposition should be consciously included within every translator's toolkit, as a versatile mechanism for use when initial more spontaneous or straightforward translations fail to fully capture the essence of a source text.

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